

Panini Linguistics Olympiad 2026

Round 1 (Junior), 15th February 2026
Question Booklet

Maximum marks: 100

Total time: 4 hours

- This question booklet has 10 pages, including this page. When the exam begins, please check and inform the invigilator immediately if your booklet has less than 10 pages.
- This question booklet has 5 problems. Each problem can have multiple assignments; the marks for each assignment are indicated next to the assignment, and the total marks for the problem are indicated next to the problem title.
- **It is not expected that you will solve every problem.** It is recommended to read all the problems before starting to solve any. You don't need to solve them in order.
- At the end of some problems, we've given you some extra information and interesting facts related to the problems in footnotes. They are not required to solve the problems but may sometimes be helpful.
- All problems will ask for short objective answers (e.g. match the following, multiple choice, one-line answers, etc.). Some problems may also ask for detailed explanations of your solutions. Your answer booklet has space for both.
 - Please write all your answers in the **specific space provided** in the answer booklet.
 - Space has also been provided for answers that require explanations. If you need extra space, you may continue outside the given space, or on the back of the sheet, or on a blank sheet that the invigilator will give you. You don't need to repeat the other answers in your explanations but you can refer to them by their number if you want to.
 - You don't need to copy the questions, problem statements, or any of the data in your answers, but you can refer to them in your own way as long as it is clear.
 - Please write the **problem number**, your **roll number**, and your **name** on **every sheet** of the answer booklet, including any extra sheets.
- You are not allowed to use any calculators, mobile phones, other electronic devices, books, notes, or other external sources of information during the exam. If you have any questions at any time, you should ask the invigilator, but you are not allowed to communicate with anyone else during the exam.

All the best!

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Problem 1: miks salat

(20 marks)

Below is a salad of words and short phrases in Naijá¹ (Nigerian Pidgin English) and their counterparts in Tok Pisin² (Papua New Guinea Pidgin English). However, the salad bowl fell off the table, and now everything is somehow even more mixed up.

Naijá/Tok Pisin

1	kis	10	small pikin	19	pikinini man
2	man pikin	11	bad belle	20	tingting paul
3	skata brain	12	eye glass	21	liklik kaikai
4	gat bel	13	carry belle	22	hau bodi
5	yu stap gut	14	liklik pikinini	23	chop maut
6	hamas	15	lusim tingting	24	kolim bel
7	kul tempa	16	hau moch	25	bel nogut
8	windo bilong fes	17	small chop	26	chop bullet
9	em kisim sut	18	komot mind		

English

27	get (a) shot/injection	32	confused	37	spectacles
28	baby	33	pacify/calm down	38	son
29	appetizers	34	forget	39	pregnant
30	hateful	35	kiss (<i>noun</i>)		
31	how are you?	36	how much (money)?		

¹Naijá, also known as Nigerian Pidgin, is an English-based creole spoken throughout Nigeria. It developed during the 17th and 18th centuries, when West Africans and English traders/colonies needed a common means of communication. Over time, it grew into a vibrant everyday language with millions of speakers, its own slang, and a lively media presence. Naijá combines English vocabulary with patterns and expressions from various Nigerian languages: Yoruba, Igbo, Edo, Hausa, and others, giving it a distinctive rhythm and flavour.

²Despite being half a world away, Tok Pisin emerged from a similar history and thus shares similarities with Naijá. It developed in the 1800s in the Pacific, when people from many different islands worked together on plantations and needed a shared language. Like Naijá, Tok Pisin is primarily based on English words. Still, its grammar and expressions are derived from the numerous local languages of Papua New Guinea. Today, it is one of the country's official languages and is spoken by millions of people.

Assignment 1 (14 marks)

Your first task is to determine which ones belong together and then match each pair to its corresponding English meaning (answer in index triples, arranged in the order Naijá-Tok Pisin-English, e.g. if you think “**101. miks**” is a Naijá word that corresponds to “**213. salat**” that is a Tok Pisin word and both mean “**72. mess**” in English, then your answer would be **101-213-72**).

Hint: Both Naijá and Tok Pisin evolved from English contact in multilingual communities; they often resemble distant cousins, sharing simple spellings, short compound words, and a love of expressive metaphors, particularly those involving body parts. At the same time, each language has its own personality and its own way of building meanings.

Assignment 2 (6 marks)

Translate the following:

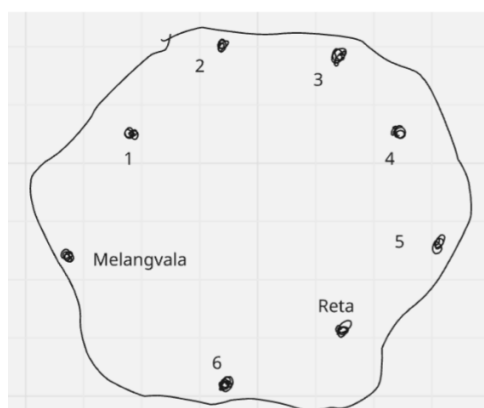
- (a) **get** (English → Tok Pisin)
- (b) **chop knuckle** (Naijá → English)
- (c) **gras bilong ai** (Tok Pisin → English)

– Mukund Choudhary

Problem 2: Blagar

(10 marks)

In the Blagar language, spoken by 10,000 people in Indonesia, many verbs of motion are used to describe coming and going between different parts of Pura island. Here is a map of the island and a location of 8 villages, with two of them labeled. The names of other villages on the island are Abira, Dolap, Harilolong, Limarahing, Malaal, and Puravematang.



Here are the verbs used for coming and going between some of villages:

Going from	Limarahing to Melangvala	ipa
	Melangvala to Reta	ipa
	Harilolong to Limarahing	ipa
	Dolap to Puravematang	mida
	Melangvala to Limarahing	mida
	Puravemetang to Melangvala	mida
Coming from	Abira to Limarahing	da
	Malaal to Dolap	da
	Reta to Dolap	da
	Malaal to Puravemetang	ja
	Malaal to Reta	ja
	Puravematang to Dolap	ja

Assignment 1 (6 marks)

Write the names of villages 1–6.

Assignment 2 (2 marks)

For going from Abira to Reta, some people say **mida** and some say **ipa**. For those that say **ipa**, which one of the two villages do they pass through on their way to Reta: Harilolong or Melangvala?

Observe the following verbs for coming and going between the villages on Pura and places on other islands in Indonesia (Makassar and Maluku):

Going from	Melangvala to Makassar	ipa
	Maluku to Harilolong	ipa
	Makassar to Abira	mida
	Limarahing to Maluku	mida
Coming from	Malaal to Maluku	da
	Reta to Makassar	ja

Assignment 3 (2 marks)

What are the motion verbs for the following:

- (a) Coming from Maluku to Dolap
- (b) Coming from Makassar to Puravemetang

– *Deeraj Pothapragada*

Problem 3: Mongolian

(20 marks)

Below are some phone numbers, and their Khalkha Mongolian³ equivalents when read out loud in arbitrary order:

- | | |
|--|-------------|
| 1. naya dal tavin gurav döčín tav | A. 99203916 |
| 2. nayan gurav tavin naim yeren tav arav | B. 94618324 |
| 3. nayan tav arvan yes döčín zurgaa dalan gurav | C. 91282187 |
| 4. nayan zurgaa teg yes xorin döröv guč | D. 90774062 |
| 5. yer dalan doloo döč žaran xoyor | E. 86092430 |
| 6. yeren döröv žaran neg nayan gurav xorin döröv | F. 85194673 |
| 7. yeren neg xorin naim xorin neg nayan doloo | G. 83589510 |
| 8. yeren yes xor' gučín yes arvan zurgaa | H. 80705345 |

Assignment 1 (4 marks)

Determine the correct correspondences.

Assignment 2 (7 marks)

When saying the numbers out loud there are three pauses. For example, (a) would be read like “naya PAUSE dal PAUSE tavin gurav PAUSE döčín neg”. For the following numbers below in your answer sheet, put “|” where the pauses should go.

- b. nayan gurav tavin naim yeren tav arav
- c. nayan tav arvan yes döčín zurgaa dalan gurav
- d. nayan zurgaa teg yes xorin döröv guč
- e. yer dalan doloo döč žaran xoyor
- f. yeren döröv žaran neg nayan gurav xorin döröv
- g. yeren neg xorin naim xorin neg nayan doloo
- h. yeren yes xor' gučín yes arvan zurgaa

Assignment 3 (5 marks)

Write the following phone numbers in digits:

- (a) yeren tav teg xoyor nayan doloo arvan doloo
- (b) naya tavin zurgaa yeren doloo teg teg

³ö is a vowel. č and ž are pronounced like ch and j respectively. ' after a consonant indicates that it is pronounced close to the palate. Khalkha Mongolian is spoken by around 3 million people.

(c) žaran zurgaa tav' gučin naim dalan yes

Assignment 4 (4 marks)

Explain how to read phone numbers aloud in Mongolian, including when to pause.

– Deeraj Pothapragada

Problem 4: Karuk

(20 marks)

Here are some words in Karuk and their translations in English, in arbitrary order:

- | | |
|-------------------|---------------------------------|
| 1. achiptik | A. black |
| 2. ahtaknih | B. car |
| 3. ahyup | C. cougar |
| 4. axakinivkih | D. deer excrement |
| 5. axakitrahyar | E. eight |
| 6. axaktikih | F. eyebrow |
| 7. axha | G. middle finger |
| 8. axkunish | H. midnight |
| 9. ikxaramkunish | I. red |
| 10. ikxaram'achip | J. seven |
| 11. ip'af | K. red deer |
| 12. ip'axkunish | L. ring finger |
| 13. kuyrakinivkih | M. to bleed |
| 14. pithvayupha | N. to have a spot over each eye |
| 15. uh'af | O. tobacco tar |
| 16. yupipih | P. twenty |
| 17. yupthukirar | Q. wildcat |

Assignment 1 (9 marks)

Match between 1-17 and A-Q, knowing that **ahpah** means “steamship”.

Assignment 2 (3 marks)

Translate to Karuk: *night, tobacco, wheel*

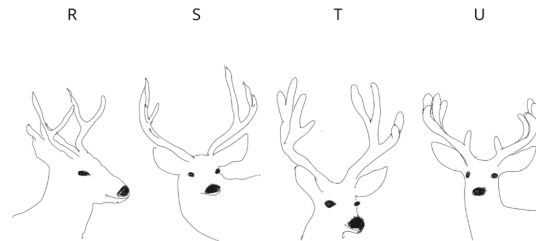
Assignment 3 (3 marks)

Translate to English: **thukinkunish, yup, ah**

Assignment 4 (5 marks)

Match between the following words in Karuk and the types of deer they describe among R-U:

- 18. **axaktak**
- 19. **itroopa'ahar**
- 20. **kuyraktak**
- 21. **pithvathip**



Tobacco tar refers to specifically the sticky, resinous substance produced when tobacco is burned. Wildcats are closely related to domestic cats and are known for their vertical yellow eyes. Panthers, also known as cougars, are related cats known for their round green eyes.

An apostrophe represents the sound in the middle of uh-oh. The Karuk language has tone and vowel length distinctions, which were not shown in this problem for simplicity.

Karuk or Ararahih'uripih is the traditional language of the Karuk people in the region surrounding the Klamath River, in Northwestern California, USA. It is spoken by 12 native speakers, and is undergoing a revival.

– Animikha Dutta Dhar

Problem 5: Dhivehi

(30 marks)

Given below are some sentences in English:

1. I take your chair.
2. The friend accidentally asks the bird.
3. Your child starts (with) the coconut.
4. I will accidentally start the white fire.
5. The fire takes the tasty coconut.
6. You will drop the small child.
7. The child accidentally takes the chair.
8. The donkey will accidentally drop the banana.
9. The bird's friend will ask me.
10. The white banana will start the fire.
11. I will hit the donkey.
12. The friend's bird will look at the fire.
13. The child looks at the tasty coconut.
14. The donkey accidentally hits the small chair.
15. The white coconut accidentally hits the chair.
16. You accidentally ask the friend.
17. The bird will accidentally drop the tasty banana.
18. The donkey accidentally looks at the small banana.

And here are their translations into Dhivehi, in arbitrary order:

- | | |
|----------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| A. Aharen himāru jahānan. | J. Raṭṭessa' dūni ehē. |
| B. Aharena' hudu alifān feṣēne. | K. Darifulu mīru kāṣi balā. |
| C. Hudu kāṭṭa' goṇḍi jehē. | L. Kalē kuḍa darifulu vaṭṭāne. |
| D. Himāra' donkeyo veṭṭēne. | M. Dūñña' mīru donkeyo veṭṭēne. |
| E. Aharen kalēge goṇḍi nagan. | N. Hudu donkeyo alifān faṣāne. |
| F. Raṭṭehīge dūni alifān balāne. | O. Kalēge darifulu kāṣi faṣā. |
| G. Alifān mīru kāṣi nagā. | P. Himāra' kuḍa goṇḍi jehē. |
| H. Kalēa' raṭṭehi ehē. | Q. Darifula' goṇḍi negē. |
| I. Dūnīge raṭṭehi aharen ahāne. | R. Himāra' kuḍa donkeyo belē. |

Assignment 1 (9 marks)

Determine the correct correspondences.

Assignment 2 (4 marks)

Translate into Dhivehi:

- (a) The white donkey hits the small banana.
- (b) I accidentally ask you.
- (c) Your child will accidentally start the coconut's fire.

(d) Your fire will accidentally start my fire.

Assignment 3 (4 marks)

Translate into English:

- (a) Aharena' dūni veṭṭēne.
- (b) Aharenge raṭṭehīge raṭṭessa' kalēge raṭṭehīge raṭṭehi jehē.
- (c) Himāru donkeyo balā.
- (d) Darifuḷu alifān faṣāne.

Assignment 4 (13 marks)

Explain any patterns and rules you found in the data.

Dhivehi is an Indo-European language of the Indo-Aryan branch spoken in Maldives. It is the official language of Maldives, and has over 500,000 speakers. It is closely related to Hindi and distantly related to English.

– Advay Misra, Vaageesan Surendran

This is the end.